

the marketers became aware of the readymade publicity platform reality shows provided. "Film stars were already doing television for free; they realised it was time they made money out of it," says Keertan Adyanthaya, executive vice-president and general manager, Star Plus. So Shah Rukh continued his TV-run with the 36-episode *Kya Aap Paanchvi Pass Se Tez Hein?* on Star and even the usually hostile Ajay Devgan and Kajol took the tube route with *Rock N Roll Family* on Zee TV where the two along with Tanuja judge families on *naach-gaana*.

Money and publicity aside, television also lets actors connect with the audience. "It also lets them bust a lot of myths created around their persona," says Sony TV business head Albert Almeida. He's probably hinting at Salman, who's shed his first-day nervousness and put his sensitive side on display for the four episodes he's shot till now. "He has an edginess and unpredictably. He doesn't march to a singular tune and that works very well," says Basu.

Stars are being relentlessly pursued also because of their advertising pull. A big ticket show like *Paanchvi Paas* or *Dus ka Dum* attracts advertisers because of its grand scale and its superstar status. If a 10-second spot in a soapy saga sells for Rs 1 lakh, the same spot on a big show sells for nothing less than Rs 4 lakh. Add stars to this and advertisers flock to the channel. Star Plus, for one, has on board 11 sponsors for its Shah Rukh extravaganza, totalling over Rs 130 crore.

Today, the audience's attention span has shrunk to a new low with the Indian Premier League (IPL) generating more TRPs (8.6) than a top-rated show on an entertainment channel. The most recent example is Shah Rukh's *Paanchvi Pass*. When compared to his earlier crore-caper, *KBC 3*, that opened with a TRP of 9.3 in January 2007, the first episode of this show only managed 4.6, slipping to 3.7 in the second. Yes, they may have beat IPL for one hour, but the question is will it sustain?

After all, though the audience might remember Bachchan's *lock kiya jaye*



URMILA MATONDKAR, WAAR PARIVAAR
She is being paid Rs **1 crore** for the 17-week show

and Shah Rukh's spitfire wit, television has also produced superstar duds like Govinda's *Jeeto Chhapar Phaad Ke* (average TRP of 3.4) and Madhuri Dixit's post-marriage outing *Kahin Naa Kahin Koi Hay* (average TRP of 1.2), both on



AKSHAY KUMAR, FEAR FACTOR
The 'Khiladi' will be paid Rs **1.5 crore** per episode

Sony TV. Manisha Koirala's *Sawaal Dus Crore Ka* on Zee TV was also disastrous. Even Star Plus's golden goose *KBC* saw a slip in TRPs with every consequent season. While opening at an average of 14.13, the subsequent seasons, *KBC 2* with Bachchan and 3 with Shah Rukh, managed average TRPs of 11.14 and 6.8, respectively. "You can only attract a certain number of people through star power. The concept has to work as well," says Zee TV business head Tarun Mehra. He should know since the Devgan 30-episode family outing's TRPs have been slipping after opening at 4.2.

In the next couple of months, television will have an overload of cricket and Bollywood. Not only big buck stars, but also have-beens like Raveena Tandon on 9X's *Chak De Bachche* and Shatrughan Sinha on Star One's *The Great Indian Laughter Challenge 4*. Urmila Matondkar, who enjoyed the limelight in *Jhalak Dikha Jaa 2*, returns to host Sony's music show *Waar Parivaar*. She is allegedly being paid Rs 1 crore for the 17-week-show—improving on her Rs 1.5-crore fee for 26-episode *Jhalak Dikha Jaa 2*.

The gain is mutual for both the channels and the actors. What they should fear is falling into a rut where one channel throws money at an actor just to grab eyeballs, making the viewer switch to watch the Kolkata Knight Riders take on the Mumbai Indians. ■